The Prescott Girls – Study Guide

The Sugar Boycott

Sugar and the Abolition Movement

During the late 1700s and early 1800s, many people in Britain and the United States began protesting the use of enslaved labor on sugar plantations in the Caribbean.

Sugar was one of the most widely traded goods in the Atlantic world. Large plantations produced sugar using the labor of enslaved Africans under extremely harsh conditions.

As the abolition movement grew, some people chose to protest slavery by refusing to buy sugar that had been produced by enslaved labor. This movement became known as the **sugar boycott**.

Why Sugar Was Important

Sugar was a common ingredient in many households. It was used in:

- tea and coffee
- baked goods
- preserves and sweets

Because sugar was so widely used, refusing to buy it became a powerful way for ordinary families to express their opposition to slavery.

A Protest in the Kitchen

Unlike many political protests, the sugar boycott often took place inside the home.

Families made choices about what they would buy, cook, and serve. Some people stopped using sugar completely, while others tried to purchase sugar that had not been produced by enslaved labor.

Women often played an important role in the boycott because they usually managed household purchases and food preparation. Choosing whether or not to serve sugar became a way for families to express their moral beliefs.

Quakers and the Sugar Boycott

Many early supporters of the sugar boycott were members of the Religious Society of Friends, often called Quakers.

Quakers were among the first religious groups to speak openly against slavery. As early as the late 1700s, Quaker meetings in both Britain and the United States encouraged members to avoid goods produced by enslaved labor whenever possible.

Because Quaker beliefs emphasized living according to one's conscience, many Friends believed that refusing slave-produced sugar was a way to practice their moral principles in everyday life. Choosing what to buy at the market or serve at the table became a small but meaningful act of protest.

Quaker communities also helped spread these ideas. Letters, pamphlets, and traveling speakers carried news of the sugar boycott between cities such as Philadelphia and smaller towns throughout New England.

Free Labor Sugar

By the early nineteenth century, some merchants began selling **"free labor sugar."** This sugar was advertised as being produced without enslaved labor.

Another alternative sometimes discussed by abolitionists was **East India sugar**, which came from British-controlled plantations in Asia rather than from Caribbean plantations dependent on enslaved labor.

People who supported abolition often preferred to buy these products even if they cost more. Stores and newspapers sometimes encouraged customers to choose goods produced without slavery.

Connections to *The Prescott Girls*

During the 1830s, debates about slavery and the products produced by enslaved labor were spreading across the northern United States.

Letters, pamphlets, church discussions, and newspaper articles helped share these ideas between cities such as Philadelphia and towns throughout New England.

In communities like those in Maine, families sometimes discussed these issues at home, at school, or in church meetings. These conversations encouraged people to think carefully about the everyday goods they used.

Why This History Matters

The sugar boycott shows how ordinary people tried to influence a large and difficult problem.

By changing their daily habits, families believed they could take part in a larger movement for social change. Even small decisions made in kitchens and marketplaces could become part of a wider protest against slavery. Choosing whether or not to buy sugar became a way for people to express their moral beliefs in their everyday lives.

The boycott also helped spread awareness about how goods were produced and where they came from. As people learned more about the conditions on Caribbean plantations, many began to think differently about the products they used at home.

Studying these actions helps us understand how people in the past expressed their beliefs and tried to shape the world around them. It also reminds us that even small choices made by individuals and families can sometimes contribute to larger movements for change.

Questions for Discussion

1. Why do you think sugar became an important focus for the abolition movement?
2. Why might refusing to buy sugar have been considered a form of protest?
3. Why were women often important participants in the sugar boycott?
4. Do people today ever boycott products for moral or political reasons?
5. What are some ways ordinary people can influence social change?

Activity

Imagine you lived in the 1830s and learned that some products were produced using enslaved labor.

Write a short letter to a friend explaining whether you would support the sugar boycott and why.

Consider:

• what information you might have heard
• how your family might feel about the issue
• what choices you might make when buying food.